

There would be no sign of impatience: he would stand there and wait until Krikor-the-Saddler had finished his talk—talks which often went on for a long time. Torrig would be so good on these occasions that it became a constant habit for Krikor-the-Saddler not to go anywhere without him.

‘Let him stay at home,’ Tourvanda Korro would say. ‘He might be a nuisance to you.’

‘No, wife, he is never a nuisance. He takes hold of my leg and just stands there. He is a very good lad.’

Tourvanda Korro would be filled with unbounded joy.

‘The orphan has found a home, and we have got ourselves a child. If we had waited for Krikor-the-Saddler, nothing would have come of it,’ she would say.

Gradually, both Krikor-the-Saddler and Tourvanda Korro felt that Torrig was an indispensable part of their home.

‘What would we have done if there wasn’t this lad?’ Krikor-the-Saddler would ask.

‘What would we have done? We would have sat and looked at one another’s miserable face,’ would reply Tourvanda Korro.

‘Torrigh, my lad,’ would call Krikor-the-Saddler.

‘Yes, Krikor Agha?’ Torrig would answer promptly.

‘Get me some water to drink.’

Torrigh would fetch the water.

Tourvanda Korro’s happiness would have no limit especially when Torrig would call her husband ‘Krikor Agha’—this was something which she had herself taught him. If no one on earth was likely to address her husband by the title of ‘Agha’, at least, Torrig would do so.

‘Torrigh, my pet, who is knocking on the door?’ Tourvanda Korro would inquire, knowing fully well that it was Krikor-the-Saddler.

‘Krikor Agha,’ would reply Torrig.

Tourvanda Korro would swell with pride and, delighted, she would take hold of Torrig’s head, would press it to her bosom, would kiss him and say:

‘May your Krikor Agha worship you!’

When Torrig grew older still, he became useful outside the house also. It would be:

‘Torrigh, lad, take this meat home!’

‘Torrigh, lad, take this bread home!’

'Torrìg, my child, go and tell your Krikor Agha to get some vinegar, and bring it home!'

'Torrìg, darling, take the basket to the shop!'

And Torrìg would do everything without a murmur, without any complaint. Only it would take him a very long time to go from the house to the shop and back again. When Krikor-the-Saddler came home and found the meal not ready, he would be astonished:

'Haven't you got the meal ready yet, Tourvanda? I am starving, wife!'

'You sent the meat home late.'

'What do you mean? I sent it this morning!'

'But it was midday when Torrìg came home!'

'Torrìg, lad!'

Torrìg would stand there and look at him obediently.

'Did you bring the meat straight home? Didn't you go anywhere else on the way?'

'No!'

Torrìg was not lying: he had gone straight home from the shop, but he had loitered so much on the way. Everything in the street interested him: if he came across a bear-show, he would stop and watch it; if he saw chickens feeding in front of a house, he would stop and watch them for a long time; and if he happened to see two united dogs, he would watch them for hours, in wonderment and delight, without knowing what was taking place. Sometimes it would happen that as he watched, somebody would snatch some bread or vegetables from under his arm. He would be delayed most of all on those days when the snow came down in large flakes. The leisurely, fluttering, and dancing particles of snow would give Torrìg immense pleasure. He would lift up his head and wait until a snow-flake landed on his eyelashes.

One day, while he was busy watching something, a dog snatched the meat away from his bag. He chased after it, but could not catch it. That evening Krikor-the-Saddler slapped him across the face and said:

'You must pull yourself together, my boy; that meat cost us money!'

Torrìg cried.

'I won't do it again, Krikor Agha!' he sobbed.

Torrìg uttered this in such a way, with such misery, with his